
The Year of Your Lower Back

Companion Workbook — map your low back's
patterns and track your progress

NATE RATCLIFF, LMT

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HEALING HANDS BY NATE

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Inner Circle Deep Cut — #1 Workbook

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Introduction

A YEAR-LONG COMPANION TO THE IC1 DEEP CUT.
Map your low back's patterns and track your progress.

CHAPTER 1

How to use this workbook

THIS IS A YEAR-LONG WORKBOOK, NOT A 7-DAY tracker. Use the pattern self-assessment when something flares. Use the 30-day tracker when you start a new home practice. Use the seasonal check-ins at the start of each season.

Bring it to every session.

CHAPTER 2

Pattern Self-Assessment

USE THIS WHEN LOW BACK PAIN SHOWS UP. Identify which pattern (or combination) you're dealing with.

Right now, my low back feels:

Where exactly? (Mark on the diagram or describe)

- ☐ Center of low back, both sides
- ☐ One side only — ☐ Right / ☐ Left
- ☐ High low back, just under the ribs
- ☐ Low into the sacrum / SI joints
- ☐ Pain radiating down a leg (SEE DOCTOR)

Pain level (0-10): [____]

Pattern questions

1. When does it hurt most? (Check all that apply)

- ☐ After sitting for a while → suggests Pattern 1 (Hip Flexor Pull)
- ☐ During lifting or carrying → suggests Pattern 2 (Glute Inhibition)

- [] When rotating, reaching behind, twisting → suggests Pattern 3 (Mid-Back Compensation)
- [] Started suddenly during specific activity → Pattern 4 (Acute Strain)
- [] On and off for 5+ years → Pattern 5 (Chronic/Recurrent)

2. What makes it better?

- [] Movement / walking
- [] Heat
- [] Hip flexor stretching
- [] Glute squeezes / bridges
- [] Opening the mid-back
- [] Nothing seems to help

3. What makes it worse?

- [] Sitting for long periods
- [] Lifting
- [] Standing too long
- [] Cold weather
- [] Stress
- [] Any movement at all (SEE DOCTOR IF SEVERE)

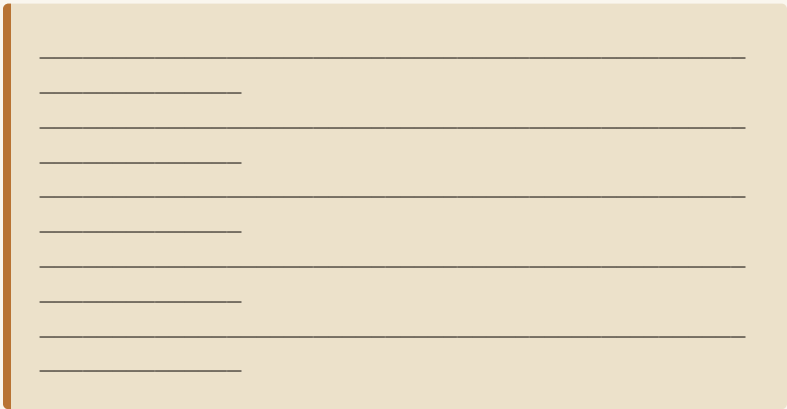
4. My best guess at which pattern I'm dealing with:

5. Specific intervention I'll try first:

CHAPTER 3

Reflection Prompts

PROMPT 1: MAP THE HISTORY OF YOUR LOW back. When did it first start bothering you? What were you doing? What life stage were you in? Are there clear patterns across years?

A writing area consisting of ten horizontal lines on a light beige background. A vertical brown line is on the left side of the area.

Prompt 2: What’s your biggest “I should have stopped” moment with your low back — a time you pushed through when you shouldn’t have? What was the consequence?

Prompt 3: If your low back could talk to you in the morning, what would it most often want to say? What would it want you to actually do (or stop doing)?

CHAPTER 4

30-Day Low Back Tracker

USE THIS WHEN YOU'RE STARTING A NEW HOME practice and want to see if it's working. Mark each day.

Daily check pattern

- Did I do my daily maintenance routine? (Y/N)
 - Pain level this morning (0-10)
 - Pain level at end of day (0-10)
 - Any specific triggers today?
 - One word for how my back feels right now
-

Week 1

DAY	DATE	ROUTINE?	AM (0-10)	PM (0-10)	TRIG- GER	ONE WORD
1						
2						
3						
4						
5						
6						
7						

Week 2

DAY	DATE	ROUTINE?	AM (0-10)	PM (0-10)	TRIG- GER	ONE WORD
8						
9						
10						
11						
12						
13						
14						

Week 3

DAY	DATE	ROUTINE?	AM (0-10)	PM (0-10)	TRIG- GER	ONE WORD
15						
16						
17						
18						
19						
20						
21						

Week 4

DAY	DATE	ROUTINE?	AM (0-10)	PM (0-10)	TRIG- GER	ONE WORD
22						
23						
24						
25						
26						
27						
28						
29						
30						

CHAPTER 5

30-Day Reflection

AVERAGE MORNING PAIN (DAYS 1-7 VS DAYS 24-30): _ → __

Average evening pain (Days 1-7 vs Days 24-30):
_ → __

Number of days I did the routine: ____ out of 30

Most common triggers:

1.

2.

3.

What's the biggest change?

What still needs work?

CHAPTER 6

Seasonal Check-Ins

USE THESE AT THE START OF EACH SEASON TO set expectations and prevention strategies.

Spring Check-In (March/April)

Date: ____

Last spring's low back lockup status: ☐ Had it /
☐ Didn't / ☐ Don't remember

Mowing season prevention plan:

Glute activation commitment: ____ reps × ____ times/
 day starting ____ (date)

Summer Check-In (June)

Date: ____

How is my back at the start of summer (0-10):

Hydration habits this summer (rate 0-10): [__]

Sleep quality lately (rate 0-10): [__]

Summer maintenance commitment:

Fall Check-In (September)

Date: _____

Cumulative load this summer (rate 0-10): [__]

Fall recovery commitment (per Module 10):

Preventive bodywork session scheduled? [Yes / No] — Date: ____

Winter Check-In (November)

Date: ____

Morning stiffness baseline now (0-10): [__]

Winter morning warm-up commitment:

CHAPTER 7

Year-End Low Back Inventory

DO THIS ONCE AT THE END OF THE CALENDAR year (or your “membership year” anniversary).

Compared to January, my low back is: ☐ Better / ☐ Same / ☐ Worse

Specific improvements:

What still needs attention:

One thing I’ll commit to for next year:

CHAPTER 8

Try this for 30 days

IF YOU DO NOTHING ELSE FROM THIS WORKBOOK, try this:

The daily maintenance routine (morning 3 min, midday 2 min, evening 5 min). Every day. For 30 days.

That's 10 minutes a day total. Spread across three windows.

If your low back has been a problem for years and you actually do this for 30 days, you'll be in a different place by day 30. Most people are.

Bring this workbook to your next session — I want to see what your tracker shows.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,
LMT and published by Healing Hands By
Nate.